read them literally, they do not argue over them literally either. The Hindu has historically refused to pick a fight over the meaning of other people's religious texts; since they cannot literally be true, to the Hindu, they can either help in self-realisation or not, but they are not worth quarrelling about. You say your holy book is the word of God? Fine; if it helps you understand your true self, if it opens your mind's eyes to the ultimate truth of Creation and helps you merge your soul into the cosmos, it will have served its purpose. Ah, you say, that's not what your holy book is supposed to do? What use is it to you then? Come, let me read it; perhaps it will help open my eyes.

This approach to theological disputation left the honest Christian missionary in colonial times somewhat confused.

THE HINDU LIFE EXPERIENCE

As a result, Hinduism occupies a unique place among the world's faiths. In it, as Dr Radhakrishnan explained:

> 'Intellect is subordinated to intuition, dogma to experience, outer expression to inward realisation. Religion is not the acceptance of academic abstractions or the celebration of ceremonies, but a kind of life or experience. It is insight into the nature of reality (*darshana*) or experience of reality (*anubhava*).'

Hindus dislike people being drafted into truth-armies firing cannons of certitudes; their instinct is to remain sceptical, open, questioning. Reason and intuition must go together. Blind belief in dogma is absent in Hinduism; all spiritual teachings are subject to disputation, and perceptions must be tested through logical thought. The Hindu sacred texts 'are not so much dogmatic dicta as transcripts from life.'

This is all very well, one might say, but what of the vast majority of Hindus, who have not read most of these sacred texts, who are unaware of the glorious capaciousness of their faith, who are inured to theological heterodoxy and scriptural eclecticism? What of those who only know Hinduism as a cultural identity, who go to their temples to pray to their *ishta-devta (*their favourite gods) when they are in trouble or distress, who observe fasts for specific deities, celebrate joyously the major festivals in their area and are conscious of their difference from those